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USER GUIDE

Innovation Idea Tracker

How to use the application

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1. About the Application

1.1 What is the Innovation Idea Tracker?

The **Innovation Idea Tracker** is a web platform where the members of an organisation, a university club or a community can **share ideas**, **vote** on the ideas of others, **discuss** them in comments and follow how each idea is **evaluated** – from its first proposal to its implementation. It replaces scattered e-mails and meetings with one transparent place where every idea is recorded and every decision is visible.

1.2 Who is this guide for?

This guide explains, step by step and without technical vocabulary, how to use the application. It is written for three kinds of users, which correspond to the three **roles** of the platform:

Table 1 – The three roles

Role	Who	What you can do
Visitor	Anyone who is not signed in	Browse and search ideas, read comments, view member profiles
Submitter	Every registered member (default role)	Everything a visitor can do, plus submit ideas, vote, comment, edit your own pending ideas, send feedback
Reviewer	Team lead or evaluator	Everything a submitter can do, plus open the review queue and evaluate other members' ideas
Administrator	Platform manager	Everything a reviewer can do, plus manage users, categories, feedback, delete any content, view statistics and export data

1.3 What you need

- A computer, tablet or phone with a recent web browser (Chrome, Firefox, Edge, Safari).
- The address (URL) of the platform given by your organisation – for a local installation: `http://127.0.0.1:5000`.
- No installation and no Internet connection to third-party sites is required: everything the interface needs is served by the application itself.

1.4 A first look at the interface

Every page shares the same layout: the **navigation bar** at the top (home, ideas, new idea, and – depending on your role – review and admin menus, the search box, the theme button and your account menu), the **content** in the middle and a **footer** with useful links. On a phone the navigation collapses into a menu button.

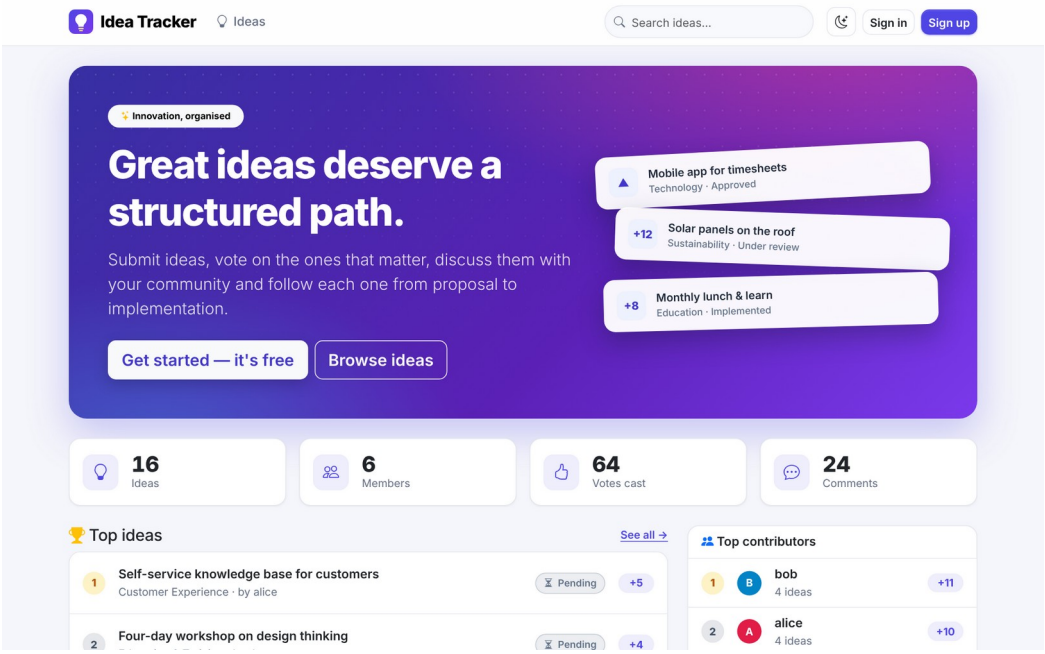


Figure 1 – The home page: statistics, top ideas and top contributors

2. Getting Started

2.1 Creating an account

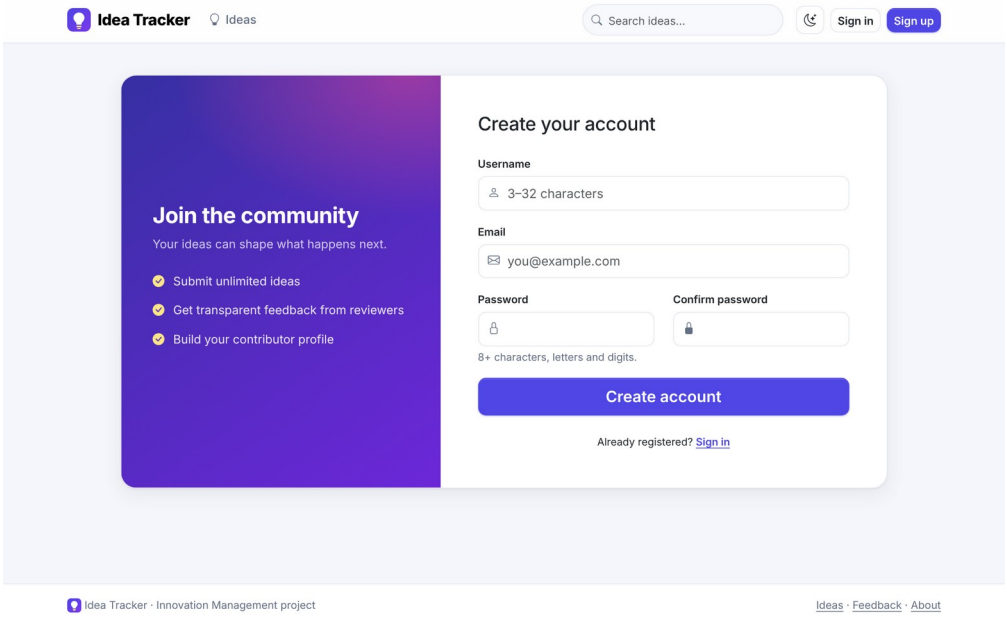


Figure 2 – The registration page

1. Click **Sign up** in the top-right corner.
2. Choose a **username** (3 to 32 characters: letters, digits, dots, dashes or underscores).
3. Enter your **e-mail address**.
4. Choose a **password** of at least 8 characters containing letters **and** digits, and type it a second time to confirm.
5. Click **Create account**. You are signed in automatically and land on the home page.

Good to know: the username and e-mail address must not be used by another member. Upper and lower case are ignored when comparing them.

2.2 Signing in and out

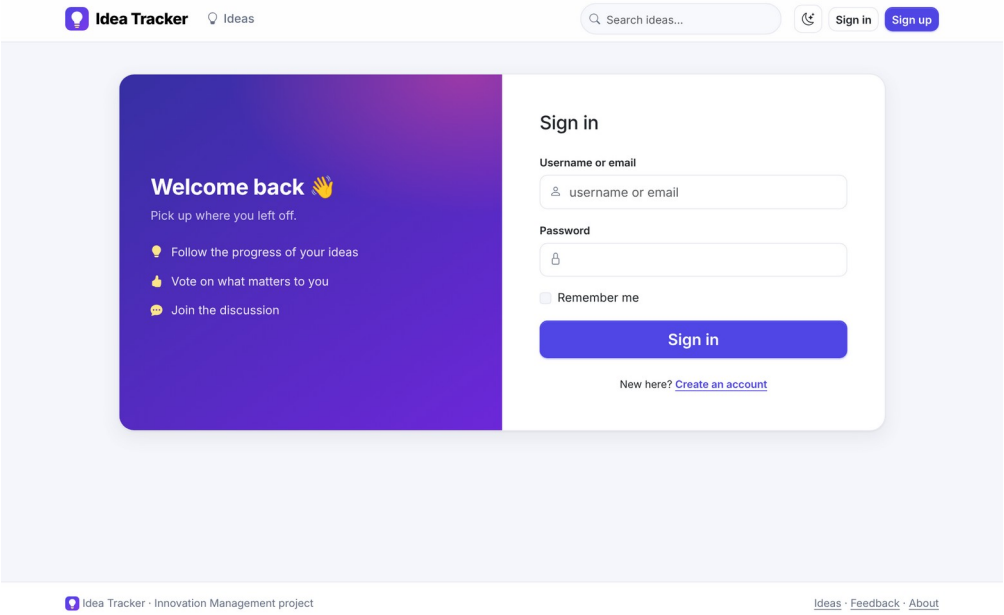


Figure 3 – The sign-in page

1. Click **Sign in**.
2. Type your **username or e-mail address** and your password. Tick **Remember me** on your own computer to stay signed in.
3. Click **Sign in**. To leave, open your account menu (your name in the top-right corner) and click **Sign out**.

For security, after **5 wrong attempts within 15 minutes** the application refuses further attempts for a while. Wait a few minutes and try again. A disabled account cannot sign in; contact an administrator.

2.3 Your profile and password

Open the account menu and choose **Profile**. You can change your e-mail address and, in a separate form, your password (you must type the current one first). Every member also has a **public profile page** (`/u/<username>`) showing their ideas and contribution statistics; click any author name to open it.

2.4 Light and dark theme

The **moon/sun button** in the navigation bar switches between the light and the dark theme. By default the application follows the setting of your device, and it remembers your choice on this browser.

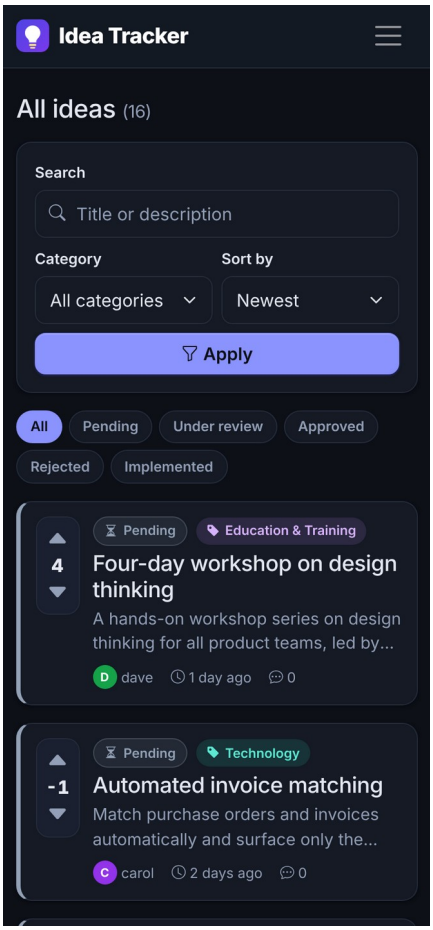


Figure 4 – The application on a phone, in dark mode

3. Finding and Reading Ideas

3.1 The Ideas page

Click **Ideas** in the navigation bar. Each idea is shown as a card with its **status**, **category**, author, age, number of comments and a **vote box** (▲ score ▼). Click a title to open the idea. Anyone can browse; no account is needed.

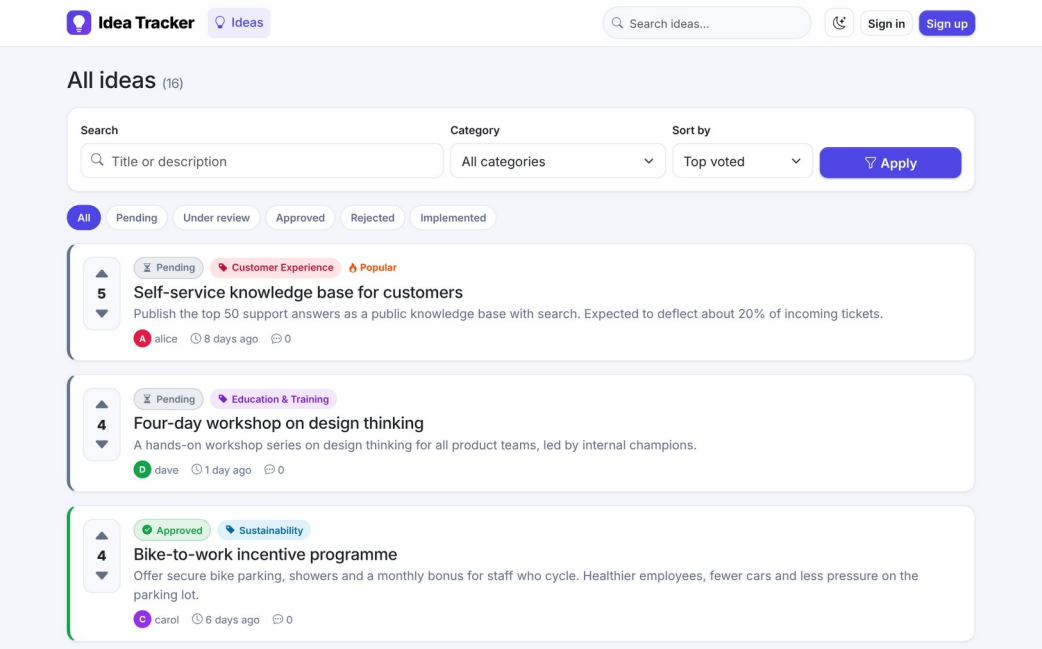


Figure 5 – The Ideas page with the filter bar and status tabs

3.2 Search, filter and sort

Table 2 – The filter bar

Control	What it does
Search	Finds ideas whose title or description contains your words (the search box in the top bar does the same)
Category	Shows only the ideas of one category
Status tabs	All, Pending, Under review, Approved, Rejected, Implemented
Sort	*Newest* · *Trending* (activity of the last 7 days) · *Top voted* · *Most discussed* · *Oldest*
Apply	Applies the search, category and sort. Results are displayed 10 per page; use the page links at the bottom

3.3 Reading an idea

An idea page shows the full description, a **progress stepper** (Submitted → Under review → Approved/Rejected → Implemented), the author and dates, the **vote box** and a **sentiment bar**

summarising how many members support or oppose the idea, the reviewer's decision and note (when there is one), **related ideas** and the **discussion**. The **copy link** button copies the address of the idea so that you can share it.

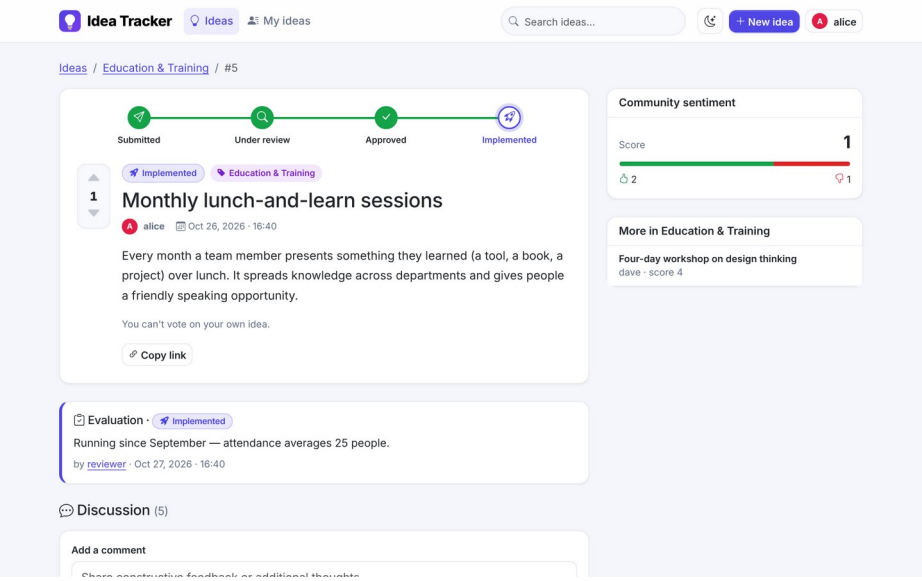


Figure 6 – An idea page seen by its author

4. Submitting and Managing Your Ideas

4.1 Submitting a new idea

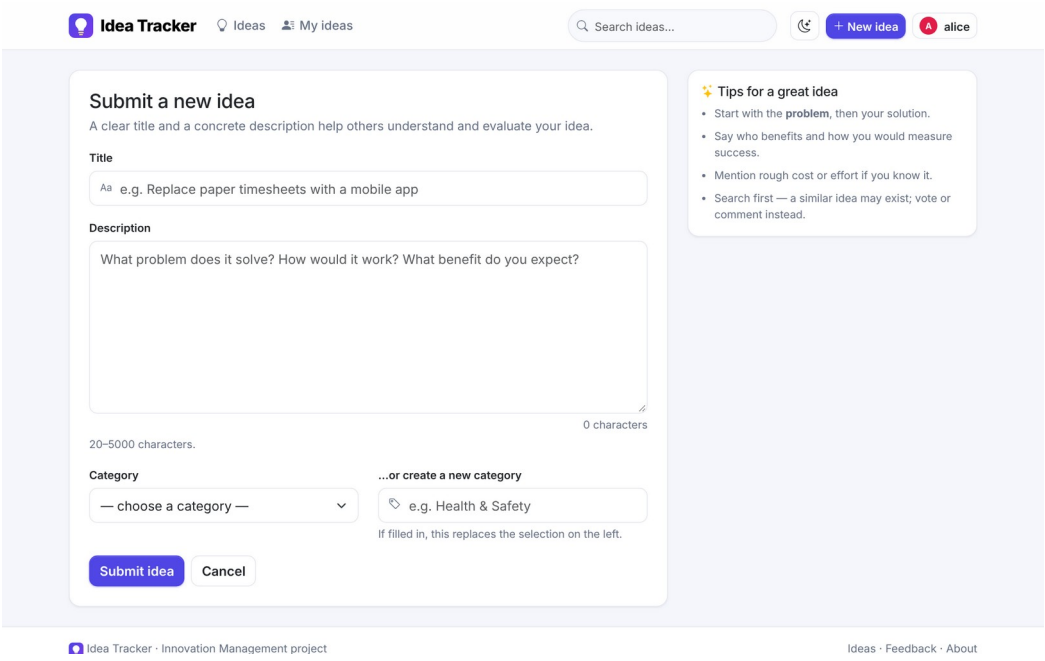


Figure 7 – The idea submission form

1. Sign in, then click **New idea** in the navigation bar.
2. Write a clear **title** (5 to 140 characters) that summarises the idea in one line.
3. Write the **description** (20 to 5000 characters): describe the **problem**, your **solution** and the **expected benefit**.
4. Choose a **category** from the list **or** type a new one in "…or create a new category". A new category becomes available to everybody; if it already exists (even with different capitals or spaces), the existing one is used.
5. Click **Submit idea**. A confirmation message appears and your idea starts with the status **Pending**.

Tips for a good idea

- Start the title with a verb or a result ("Create a shared calendar for room booking").
- Explain **who** benefits and **how much** effort it needs.
- Check first that a similar idea does not already exist; vote and comment on it instead.

4.2 My ideas

My ideas (account menu or navigation bar) lists everything you have submitted, with the status and score of each idea.

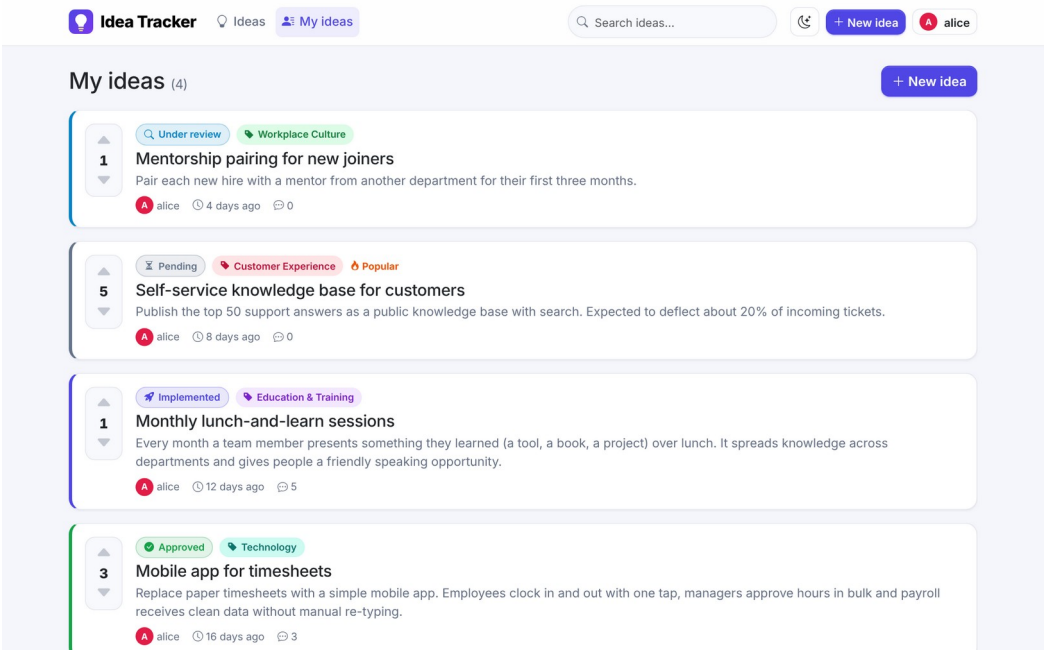


Figure 8 – The "My ideas" page

4.3 Editing or deleting an idea

While an idea is **Pending**, its author sees **Edit** and **Delete** buttons on the idea page. Once a reviewer has handled the idea, it is locked so that evaluations remain trustworthy; use a **comment** to add information. Deleting an idea is permanent and also removes its votes and comments, so a confirmation is requested.

5. Voting

Voting shows which ideas the community supports. Use the vote box on the list or on the idea page:

- ▲ means “I support this idea”, ▼ means “I do not”. The number between the arrows is the score (supporters minus opponents).
- You have **one vote per idea**. Click the **same arrow again** to withdraw your vote, or click the **other arrow** to change it.
- The score updates **instantly**, without reloading the page.
- You **cannot vote on your own idea**: the arrows are greyed out and a tooltip explains why.
- You must be signed in to vote; otherwise you are invited to sign in.

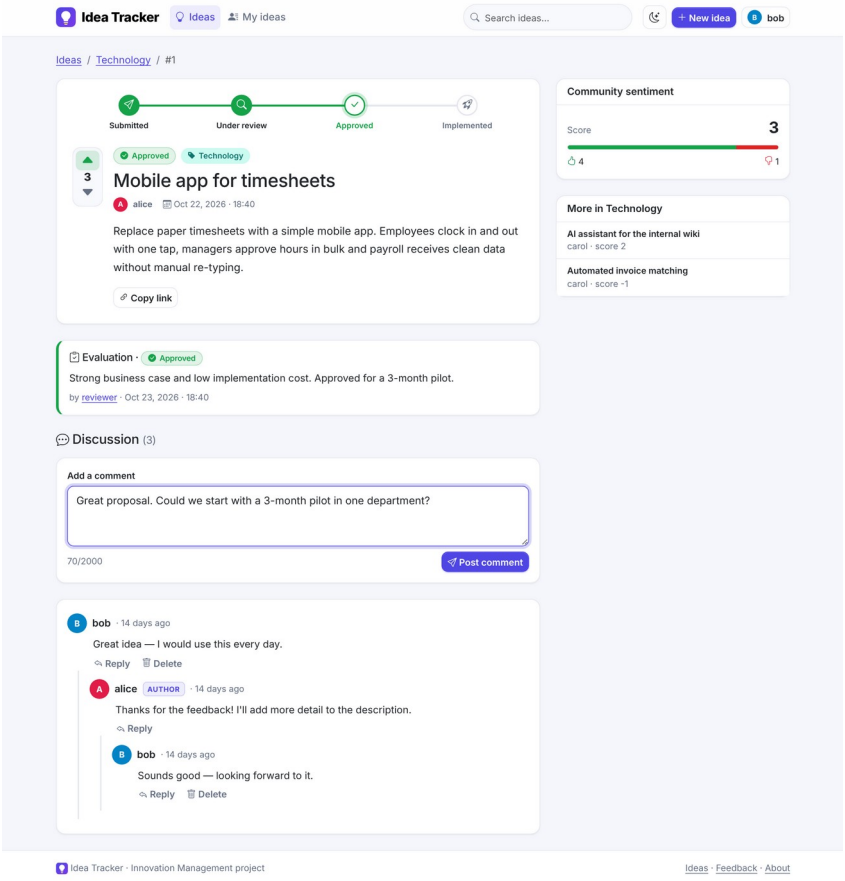


Figure 9 – An idea page as seen by another member: active vote box, sentiment bar and discussion

6. Commenting and Discussing

1. Open an idea and scroll to **Discussion**.
2. Type your comment (up to 2000 characters) and click **Post comment**.
3. To answer a particular comment, click **Reply** below it, type your answer and send it. Replies appear **indented** below the comment they answer, forming a thread.
4. Click the **bin icon** on your own comment to delete it. Administrators can delete any comment.

If a comment that has replies is deleted, it is replaced by “[comment removed]” so that the rest of the conversation stays understandable. Comments are shown as plain text; formatting characters or HTML typed in a comment are displayed as typed, never executed.

7. Idea Statuses

Every idea follows the same lifecycle. The current status is always visible on the card, on the idea page and in the progress stepper.

Table 3 – Statuses

Status	Meaning
Pending	Submitted and waiting for a reviewer. The author can still edit or delete it
Under review	A reviewer is evaluating the idea
Approved	Accepted for realisation; the reviewer may add a note
Rejected	Not pursued; the reviewer explains why in the note
Implemented	The idea has been carried out

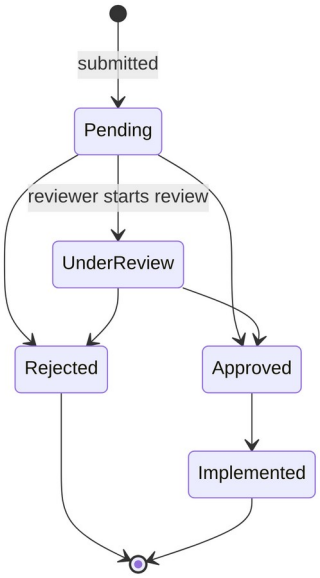


Figure 10 – Lifecycle of an idea

8. Guide for Reviewers

This chapter applies to accounts with the **reviewer** (or administrator) role.

8.1 The review queue

Open **Review** in the navigation bar. A red badge shows how many ideas are waiting. The queue lists ideas **oldest first**, each with three one-click actions: **Start review**, **Approve** and **Reject**. Use the tabs to switch between pending ideas, ideas under review and all open ideas.

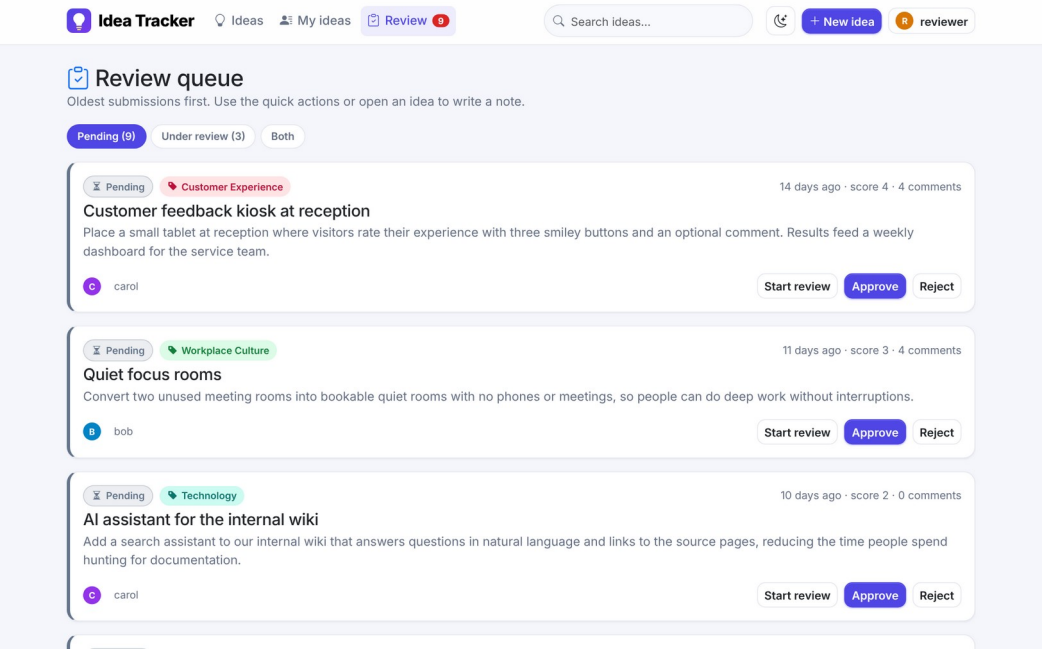


Figure 11 – The review queue

8.2 Writing a decision

1. Open the idea. In the right column an **Evaluation** panel is displayed.
2. Choose the new **status** (Pending, Under review, Approved, Rejected, Implemented).
3. Write a **note** visible to everybody that justifies the decision. A clear note encourages contributors to keep participating.
4. Click **Save evaluation**. Your name and the date appear next to the decision.

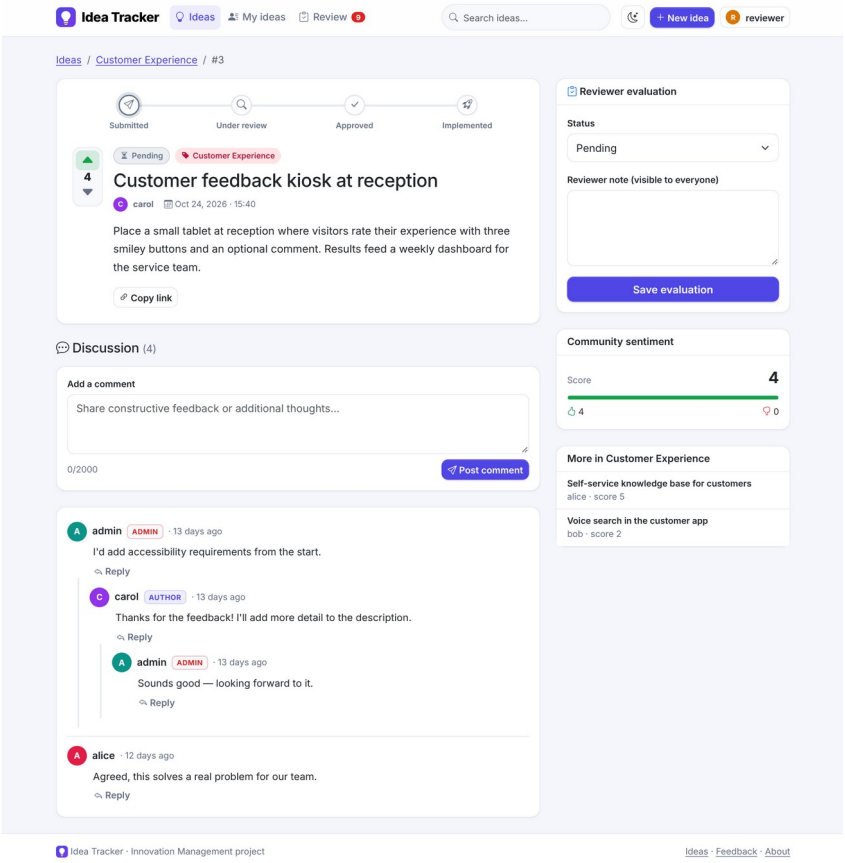


Figure 12 – The evaluation panel on an idea page

Rule: you cannot evaluate your own ideas (conflict of interest). Another reviewer or an administrator must do it.

9. Guide for Administrators

The **Admin** menu appears for accounts with the administrator role.

9.1 Dashboard

The dashboard gives the key figures of the platform – members, ideas, votes, comments, pending ideas and open feedback – and two charts: ideas **by status** and ideas **by category**.

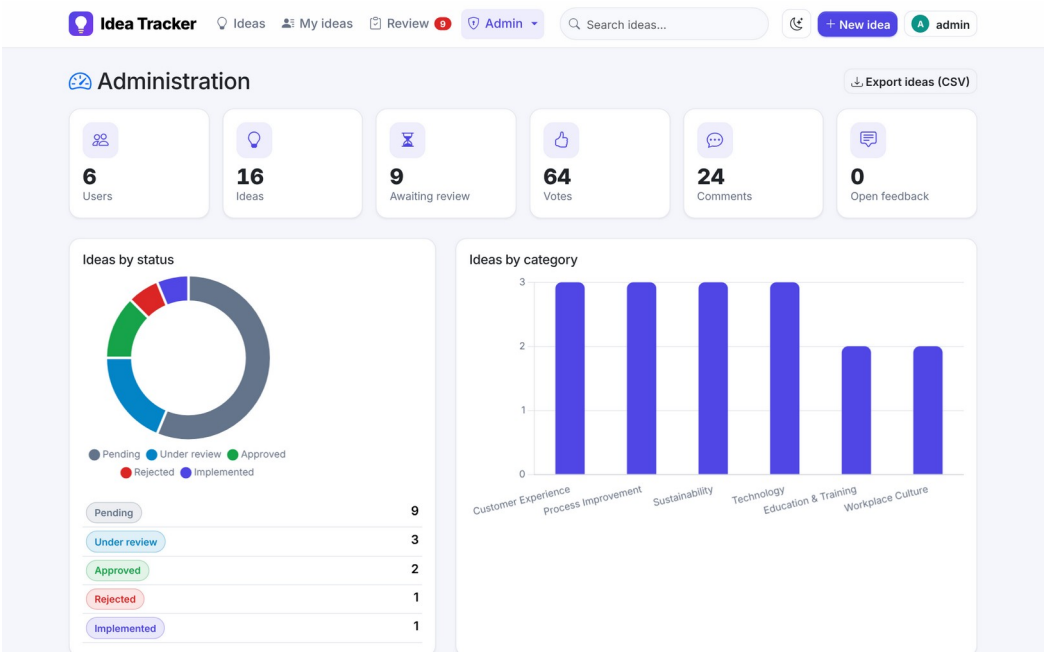


Figure 13 – The administration dashboard

9.2 Managing users

Admin → Users lists the members with their role and state. You can search by name or e-mail, **change a role** (submitter, reviewer, administrator) and **disable or enable** an account. A disabled member cannot sign in and is rejected immediately, even if currently signed in. For safety you cannot change or disable your own account, and the last active administrator cannot be disabled or demoted.

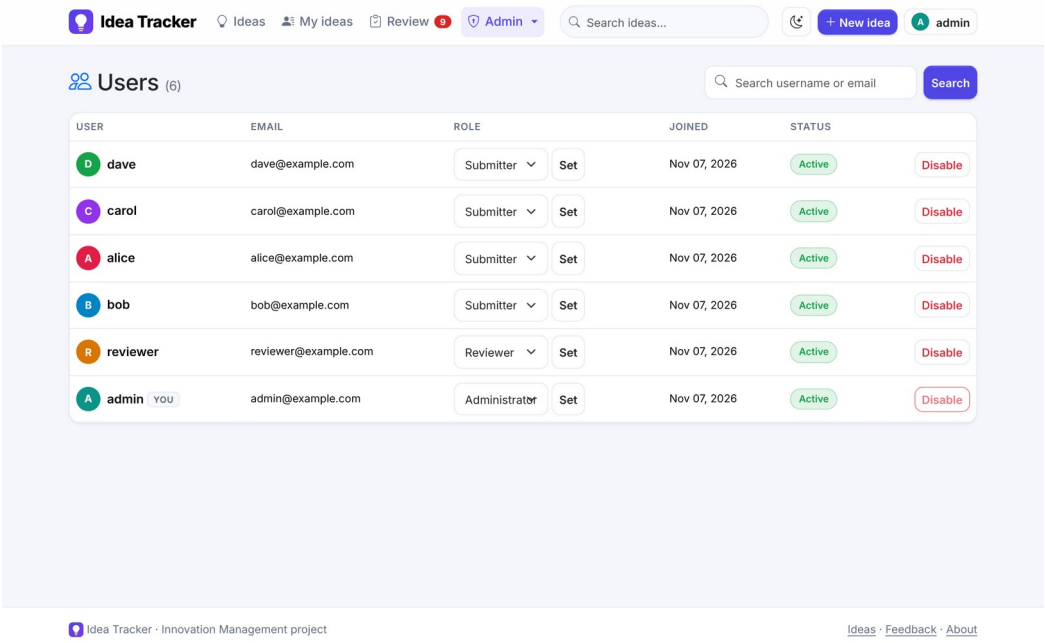


Figure 14 – User management

9.3 Managing categories

Admin → Categories lets you add a category (name and description), rename it or delete it. A category that is still used by ideas cannot be deleted; this keeps the data consistent.

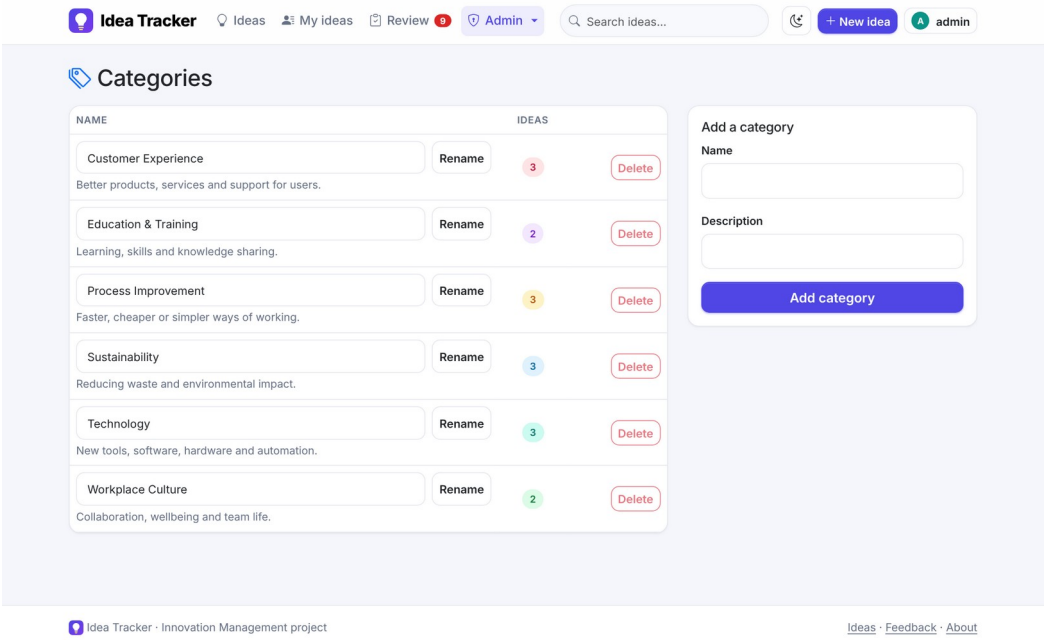


Figure 15 – Category management

9.4 Feedback inbox and CSV export

Admin → Feedback lists the messages sent by members, with their type (bug, suggestion, other); mark a message as **resolved** when it is handled. **Admin → Export** downloads all ideas as a **CSV** file that opens in Excel or any spreadsheet program.

9.5 Moderation

Administrators can delete any idea or comment (bin buttons on the idea page). Use this for spam or inappropriate content; deleting an idea removes its votes and comments permanently.

10. Sending Feedback about the Platform

Have you found a problem or do you have an idea to improve the platform itself? Use **Feedback** in the account menu or in the footer. Choose a type (**Bug**, **Suggestion** or **Other**), describe the situation and send. Administrators read every message, and the platform therefore improves with its users.

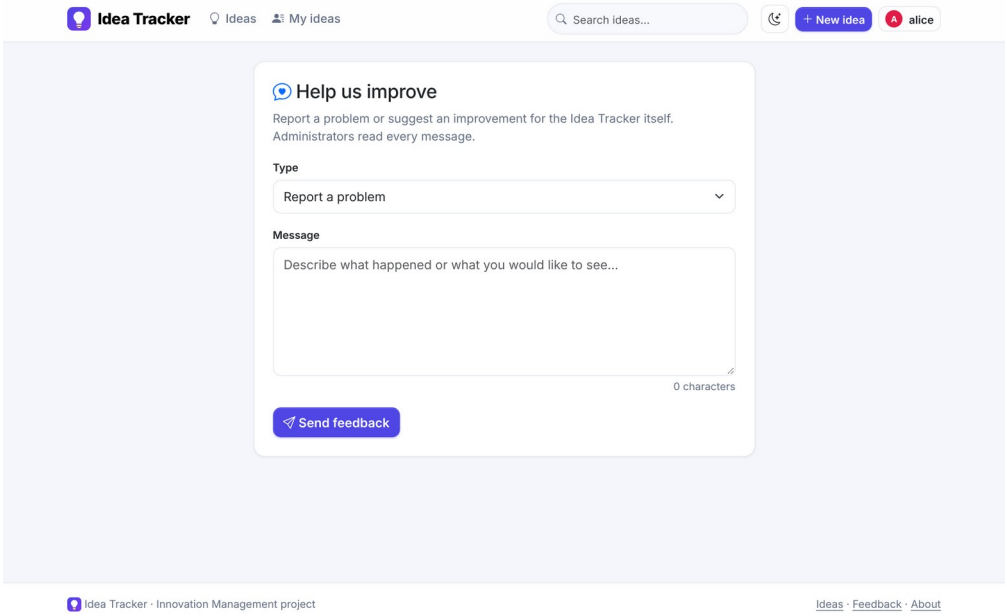


Figure 16 – The feedback form

11. Troubleshooting and FAQ

Table 4 – Common problems

Problem	Solution
“Your form session expired”	Reload the page and submit the form again (forms expire after 8 hours)
I cannot vote	Sign in first. You also cannot vote on your own idea
I cannot edit my idea	It has already been reviewed. Add a comment instead
“Too many failed attempts”	Wait 15 minutes before trying to sign in again
My account is disabled	Contact an administrator
I forgot my password	There is no automatic reset yet: ask an administrator for help
The page looks too bright/dark	Use the moon/sun button in the navigation bar
A category I need is missing	Type it in “…or create a new category” when you submit an idea

Frequently asked questions

Can I change my vote? Yes, click the other arrow. **Can I remove my vote?** Yes, click the same arrow again. **Who sees my vote?** Only the totals are displayed. **Can others edit my idea?** No; only you (while Pending) and administrators. **Does it work on a phone?** Yes, the layout adapts to small screens.

12. Quick Reference

Table 5 – What each role can do

Action	Visitor	Submitter	Reviewer	Admin
Browse, search, read comments and profiles	✔	✔	✔	✔
Submit ideas, vote, comment, send feedback	–	✔	✔	✔
Edit or delete own idea (while Pending)	–	✔	✔	✔
Evaluate ideas of others, review queue	–	–	✔	✔
Delete any idea or comment	–	–	–	✔
Manage users, categories, feedback; dashboard; CSV export	–	–	–	✔

Demonstration installation: after `python seed.py` the accounts `admin`, `reviewer`, `alice`, `bob`, `carol` and `dave` exist, all with the password `Demo1234`. These accounts are for local tests only.